Instructor Guide: Lesson 4 — Presenting Data and Recommendations

Duration: 1 hour

Topic-by-Topic Teaching Notes

Telling a Data Story

Open by contrasting two versions of the same OrbitCo opening sentence. Opening A: "We collected 30 days of incident data, ran the standard pivots, and observed the following trends." Opening B: "We need to refactor our top three runbooks before we make a hiring decision — here is the 30-day data that led us there." Ask the class which opening an executive will listen through. The difference is not content — both will deliver the same slides — but framing. Follow up by asking which opening a technical peer would prefer; Opening A is often closer to the right frame for peer review, because it respects the audience's need to see the analysis.

The point to land is that framing is a choice that depends on audience, not a universal rule. The four-part problem → evidence → options → recommendation structure from Lesson 3 still applies in both cases; the lead is what changes. Lesson 4 is where that audience-reading skill gets practiced on the same OrbitCo findings.

A common misread from students at this point: they conflate "compressed format" with "no narrative." The three compressed-format exceptions (urgent incident review, recurring status meeting, deep technical working session) are not narrative-free — they have different structural containers. Urgent incident reviews have a timeline-and-facts structure; status meetings have a KPIs-exceptions-asks structure. It is worth naming that distinction explicitly so students do not leave thinking "narrative is optional."

Choosing and Annotating Charts for the Message

This is the single most valuable live demo in the module. Take the OrbitCo weekly trend chart from a learner's Lesson 2 dashboard (or a reference copy) and transform it on the projector. Start with the default Excel version — generic title, full gridlines,

default colors. Change the title to a sentence that names the finding. Add a callout on the week-4 data point. Strip the gridlines. Recolor so only the week-4 marker is in the accent color and the rest of the series is neutral grey. Add a plain-language takeaway label below the chart.

At each step, ask the class whether the chart is more or less usable. The answer is always "more." Five minutes of transformation converts a chart that displays data into a chart that delivers an argument. The before-and-after contrast is what students remember and what they replicate in their own decks during the capstone.

One pitfall to name explicitly: "annotation" does not mean "decoration." Callouts that are decorative — arrows that point nowhere in particular, labels that restate what the axis already says — make the chart worse, not better. Every annotation should name a specific point on the chart or a specific takeaway; if it does neither, remove it.

Adapting for Different Audiences

Walk through the executive-vs-technical cut on the OrbitCo briefing. Show your own five-slide executive version alongside a 15-to-20-slide technical version of the same findings. The data is identical across both; the cuts and the lead are different. Name the rule out loud: "Same data everywhere. Never round for executives and keep exact figures for peers — the numbers are the same. What changes is how much of the reasoning makes the edit."

The "cut from a master" pattern is the one to emphasize. Building two decks from scratch inevitably drifts — the numbers subtly differ, the emphasis contradicts, and the audience for each version walks away with a slightly different story. Cutting from a single source forces the story to stay consistent.

On handouts: make sure the class understands that a handout is not "the slide deck with more words per slide." A handout is a different artifact with different design rules. A slide's job is to support the room; a handout's job is to support asynchronous reading. If your findings need more than five to seven slides' worth of detail, produce a handout in addition to the slides, not instead of them.

Preparing for and Handling Q&A

Ask the class: "Tell me about a time you were asked a question in a meeting you could not answer. How did you handle it?" Let a few people share. The contrast between "I made something up and it got worse" and "I said I do not know, I will follow up, and nothing bad happened" is always in the room somewhere. Use that real experience to motivate the "I do not know" rule. It is the simplest and most counter-intuitive lesson in the course: saying you do not know an answer is stronger than faking one, because every audience has seen fakes and they notice.

The bridging pattern (acknowledge → answer → reconnect) takes a minute to explain and benefits from one in-class practice round. Ask a learner to give the OrbitCo recommendation in 20 seconds, then give them a wandering or loaded question ("but what about tool vendor choice?" or "why did it take you 30 days to notice this?"), and ask them to bridge back to the recommendation. Two rounds of this with different learners is enough to make the pattern stick.

Presenter Tools and Basic Accessibility

Demo Presenter View on the projector while one of your own decks runs. Show how the notes pane appears on your laptop and how the fullscreen slide projects on the room. Then demo Rehearse Timings on a short three-slide deck — show the per-slide times at the end and talk through what a 90-second slide means ("too much content or I am over-explaining; either cut the slide or cut the narration").

For accessibility, the single most valuable demo is alt text. Right-click a chart → Edit Alt Text. Show how a screen reader would read the chart, using the macOS VoiceOver or Windows Narrator command if available. Even without a screen reader demo, typing a good alt-text sentence on a projected chart makes the point visible: the image is now readable by systems that cannot see the pixels. The PowerPoint Accessibility Checker (Review → Check Accessibility) is also worth projecting briefly — it catches most of the common issues automatically.

Capstone Rubric

Walk the rubric explicitly before launching the capstone activity. The four dimensions (data handling, visualization, presentation, communication) map directly onto the work students did across the whole course — Lessons 1 and 2 for the first two dimensions, Lessons 3 and 4 for the second two. Students who see that mapping

early treat the capstone as an integration exercise rather than a new assignment. Project the rubric on the wall during the capstone activity so learners can self-check as they build.

Timing Suggestions

Segment	Time	Notes
Telling a Data Story	6 min	Opening A vs Opening B contrast; name the three compressed-format exceptions
Choosing and Annotating Charts for the Message	6 min	Live chart-transformation demo (default Excel → annotated briefing chart)
Adapting for Different Audiences	5 min	Executive-vs-technical cut on the OrbitCo findings; cut-from-master pattern
Preparing for and Handling Q&A	5 min	Anticipated-questions list; one in-class bridging practice round
Presenter Tools and Basic Accessibility	4 min	Presenter View + Rehearse Timings demo; alt-text and Accessibility Checker
Activity: OrbitCo 5-Minute Capstone Briefing	30 min	Plan (5 min) + build (15 min) + rehearse (5 min) + deliver (5 min per learner in small groups)
Activity: Peer Feedback Round	10 min	Rubric-tied written feedback exchanged in pairs
Wrap-Up and Reflection	4 min	Key takeaways; one reflection question live
Buffer	-10 min	Capstone delivery timing is load-bearing — keep lecture compact and protect the 30-min capstone window
Total	**60 min**	

Common Student Questions

Q: What if my OrbitCo findings do not actually support a single recommendation? The data is ambiguous. A: Then your recommendation is "collect more data" or "run a specific experiment" — but it is still a recommendation. Ambiguous findings do not excuse the presenter from making a call; they require the call to be "we need X to decide," stated as explicitly as any other recommendation. The worst outcome of an ambiguous briefing is a room that leaves without a next action. Always name the next action, even when the next action is "get more evidence."

Q: How do I know when a question during Q&A deserves a detailed answer versus a brief answer and bridge? A: Ask yourself whether the question is the question you are in the room to answer. If it is — "why is MTTR up?", "what is the cost of runbook refactoring?" — answer it in detail. If it is adjacent but not central — "what tool vendors did you consider?", "did the support team consider a different ticketing system?" — bridge back. The test is whether answering in detail moves the audience toward the decision on the table. If it does, answer. If it pulls them off the decision, bridge.

Q: Is five slides really enough for a full 30-day review? The data seems like it wants to be ten slides. A: The data is not the constraint — the time budget is. A five-minute briefing at 45 to 60 seconds per slide gives you five to seven slides. The rest goes to an appendix or a handout. If the material feels like 10 slides, your appendix is the place for the five slides that do not make the briefing. Those appendix slides are how you handle "can you go deeper?" during Q&A without rebuilding on the fly.

Q: Do I need to use Presenter View if I am only presenting to two or three people? A: Yes. Presenter View gives you the next-slide preview and the speaker notes pane, both of which help regardless of audience size. The only time you might skip it is on a laptop-only presentation where the audience is literally behind your screen — but even then, most small meetings have someone on a second monitor or a dongle-connected TV, and Presenter View works there.

Q: If my appendix is 15 slides, how do I find the right one during Q&A without scrolling through all of them? A: Use the slide number shortcut. In Presenter View, typing a number and pressing Enter jumps to that slide. Write a one-line index on the final

visible slide ("Appendix: A6 cost breakdown, A7 severity by team, A8 prior quarter") so you know the numbers without memorizing them. A good presenter's appendix is indexed; an unorganized appendix is unusable under pressure.

Facilitation Tips

- **Run the chart-transformation demo live; do not show a finished example.** The teaching value is in watching the chart change under your mouse. A learner who sees you strip gridlines and change a title from "Weekly Tickets" to a sentence remembers the steps. A learner who sees only a finished annotated chart remembers the aesthetic but not the procedure.
- **Protect the 30-minute capstone window.** The capstone is the load-bearing activity of the whole course. If the lecture portion runs over, cut the deepest demo (probably Rehearse Timings or the accessibility demo), not the capstone time. Students need 5 min to plan, 15 min to build, 5 min to rehearse, and 5 min per learner in small groups to deliver. 30 minutes is already compressed.
- **Time every briefing with a visible timer.** The five-minute constraint is part of the capstone, and learning to finish on time is one of the skills being evaluated. Do not cut a learner off on their first try, but name it in feedback: "you had three minutes left when you got to the recommendation — next time, get there in two."
- **Keep feedback rubric-tied.** "Your intro was good" is useless; "starting with the recommendation saved me the first minute of wondering where this was going" is actionable. Model the first round yourself so the class sees the specificity bar.
- **Name the capstone as integration, not a new assignment.** Students who hear "this is where everything from Lessons 1 to 4 comes together" treat the capstone differently than students who hear "here is the final activity." The framing matters — it is what converts the four lessons from a sequence of skills into a coherent practice.